

KIN IS KING



AMIT DESHMUKH Son of Union Minister Vilasrao Deshmukh and Maharashtra Youth Congress vice-president wins by over 34,000 votes.



PRANITI SHINDE Founder of Jai-Jui NGO, Praniti Shinde is the daughter of Union Power Minister S.K. Shinde. She wins from Solapur City Central.



PANKAJA MUNDE-PALAVE A management graduate from the US, she is BJP General Secretary Gopinath Munde's daughter. Wins from Parli.



PANKAJ BHUJBAL The son of Deputy Chief Minister and NCP leader Chhagan Bhujbal wins in Nandgaon. He had lost from Mazgaon in 2004.



RAJENDRA SHEKHAWAT The President's son beat sitting Congress MLA Sunil Deshmukh who turned rebel after being denied the ticket.

THE BIG LOSERS



VIJAYSINH MOHITE PATIL The rural development minister and NCP heavyweight loses Pandharpur seat to party rebel Bharat Bhalke.



RAMDAS KADAM Leader of the Shiv Sena loses to NCP's Bhaskar Jadhav in Guhagar. His seat Khed merged with Guhagar due to delimitation.



RAVINDRA PATIL The Congress minister from Pen in Raigad loses to Dhairyasheel Patil of the Peasants and Workers Party of India



ROHIDAS PATIL Congress heavyweight from Dhule Rural lost to Sharad Patil of the Shiv Sena.



SIDDHARAM MHETRE The Congress minister loses to BJP in Akkalkot after a firing incident in Shevgaon where a BJP worker was killed.

the Shiv Sena and, as they say, the winner takes it all.

Of course, the defeat of the saffron combine goes far beyond the urban demolition by Raj. The BJP is paying for its absence as a credible opposition through the tenure of the Congress-NCP regime. It may have tried to trump up the issues of farmer suicides and price rise closer to the polls but the cynicism of the campaign did more damage than good. Internal dissension and poor ticket distribution were the other usual causes of the debacle. Familial ties seem to have overwhelmed party interests. The BJP may have retained its tally of 19 seats in Vidarbha, but Munde's base in Marathwada has shrunk. Of the six assembly constituencies in Beed, Munde's influence has waned in five except the one in Parli, where his daughter Pankaja has won. While the party has grown in regions like Konkan and Western Maharashtra, it's not enough to take on the might of the Congress.

Significantly, the voters have chosen rather decisively. If the aggrieved Marathi *manoos* has voted for the MNS and against the Shiv Sena, the others happy with the Congress-NCP combine have voted with the front and rejected the new-fangled Third Front. The clear majority to the alliance means it will no longer be held to ransom by the infamous "others". The rebels haven't had it easy either. At another level the rant about dynasties has left voters unmoved. Over 14 sons and daughters of Congress leaders and another eight from BJP and NCP were handed tickets and most have, in fact, won. Even novices like Praniti Shinde, Union Minister Sushilkumar Shinde's daughter, have managed a home



run thanks to their daddies.

There are losers among the winners and some very big losers. Even party loyalists for long have not been spared the axe. The irony of elections is that one may have been in power and performed consistently but it doesn't mean the voters will push the button in their favour. From unexpected surprises like NCP stalwart Vijaysinh Mohite Patil from Pandharpur, Shiv Sena leader Ramdas Kadam from Guhagar or even Congress heavyweight from Dhule Rural, Rohidas Patil, all have lost their shirts in these elections.

Nor did the voters oblige rebels. The trend of rebellion may have picked up during these elections, but with established leaders biting the dust as